or be diverted towards Kashmir by the ISI. Fazlur Rehman Khalil, leader of the Harkat-ul-Mujahideen, had already crossed into Afghanistan to join the Taliban in its fight against the US. There was, however, a curious and subtle conciliatory twist to India's diplomacy on the Taliban even then. Vajpayee, though resolute in his advocacy of a Taliban-free Afghanistan, accepted incorporation of 'moderate' Taliban figures in the new Afghan political dispensation.[107] Who exactly these people were was unclear, but the catch was that they will not be part of mainstream politics as 'Taliban', but could be included in a different, more tolerant, incarnation.[108]

To ally, or not to ally

As Indian officials debated whether or not to support the US in Afghanistan, the Commander-in-Chief of the US Pacific Command Admiral Dennis Blair and US Secretary of Defence Donald Rumsfeld emphasised improved India-US defence ties. Navy-to-navy and high-tech defence cooperation, Blair stated, could form the 'most significant' component of this bilateral relationship. Indeed, while Vajpayee was in Russia soon after 9/11, the *USS O'Brien* stood silently docked in Chennai.[109] Against international maritime laws, India had even escorted the US warship through the Malacca Straits inviting objections from Malaysia.[110] In late November, just before the Bonn Conference began, Blair paid an official visit to New Delhi. Even though Vajpayee denied media reports of a Cabinet meeting in early November to discuss the possibility of entering into a military alliance with the US, Blair did meet the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS), the highest decision-making body on matters of national security, to seek India's military support.[111] The meeting was both critical and highly sensitive, and its details remain classified.

In the meeting, chaired by Vajpayee (and attended by Jaswant Singh, Brajesh Mishra, defence minister George Fernandes, home minister L K Advani and the chiefs of the three military services of India), Blair made a formal request for access to Indian naval and air bases for International Security Assistance Force (ISAF) planes and carriers, and Indian troops on the ground in Afghanistan.[112] Blair's demand was ironic given Pakistan's active collaboration in the war by this